Alcaraz Gets His Revenge to Win First Paris Masters Title

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Sixty days. That is how long Carlos Alcaraz waited for his **rematch** with Ben Shelton. Back in September, Alcaraz's comeback tournament ended in a late-night, five-set **epic** at the US Open. Shelton won that one. On Sunday in Paris, Alcaraz got even. The 23-year-old Spaniard beat world number four Shelton 7-6 (7-5), 7-5 to win his first Paris Masters title. It was a tense final, and Alcaraz had to dig deep from the very start. In the opening set, he saved all six **break points** against him, refusing to let Shelton break through. Then, trailing 4-3 in the **tie-break**, he won four of the final five points to steal the set. Shelton struck first in the second set, breaking Alcaraz in his third service game. But with Shelton serving for a 5-3 lead, Alcaraz hit back. Moments later, he pointed to his ear, asking the crowd for more noise, and even danced to the music in the stadium during the change of ends. He closed out the title on a second match point, winning five of the final six games.

'It's something I've been chasing for a long time,' Alcaraz said. 'Today was one of the toughest challenges we have in tennis right now, facing Ben.' The win was special because of the road back. Alcaraz had spent four months out with a wrist injury before returning at the US Open. Since that loss to Shelton, he has won three titles and lost only once in 17 matches.

The Paris crown is his ninth ATP Masters 1000 title overall, and he has now won seven of the nine Masters 1000 events. Only Canada and Shanghai remain. Next up is the ATP Finals in Turin, where the seven-time major winner arrives on a nine-match **winning streak** after also triumphing in Vienna.

Word Treasure

rematch -- A second match between the same two players.

break points -- Chances for the player receiving serve to win the other player's service game.

tie-break -- A short extra part of a set, played when the score is tied, to decide who wins the set.

epic -- A very long and exciting contest.

winning streak -- A run of wins in a row without losing.

Background you need

The Paris Masters is one of the biggest tennis tournaments on the men's tour, and winning it is a major prize for any player.

Alcaraz and Shelton had already met at the US Open, where Shelton ended Alcaraz's return from a long injury break.

Alcaraz had spent four months out with a wrist injury, so this win was part of his road back to the top of the game.

His next test is the ATP Finals in Turin, the season-ending event for the year's best players.

Break it down

LEAD: Carlos Alcaraz beat Ben Shelton 7-6 (7-5), 7-5 to win his first Paris Masters title, 60 days after Shelton beat him at the US Open.

KEY EVENT: The Paris final

+- FIRST SET: Alcaraz saved all six break points, then won four of the final five points in the tie-break from 4-3 down.

+- SECOND SET: Shelton broke first, but Alcaraz hit back as Shelton served for a 5-3 lead and closed out the title on his second match point.

+- CROWD MOMENT: Alcaraz pointed to his ear for more noise and danced to the stadium music.

BACKGROUND: Alcaraz had spent four months out with a wrist injury; since the US Open loss he has won three titles and lost only once in 17 matches.

WIDER PICTURE: It is his ninth ATP Masters 1000 title, and he has won seven of the nine Masters 1000 events; next is the ATP Finals in Turin on a nine-match winning streak.

Why it matters

Comebacks take patience: Alcaraz shows that losing to the same opponent can be the start of a strong run back, and that saving your best tennis for the biggest points can turn a match around.

Test what you remember

1. How many days did Alcaraz wait for his rematch with Shelton?

(A) 90 days
(B) Six months
(C) 60 days
(D) 30 days

2. What was the score of the Paris final?

(A) 7-5, 6-3
(B) 6-7, 7-6, 6-2
(C) 7-6 (7-5), 7-5
(D) 6-4, 6-4

3. How many break points did Alcaraz save in the opening set?

(A) Four
(B) Six
(C) Three
(D) None

4. What happened when Shelton was serving for a 5-3 lead in the second set?

(A) The match was stopped by rain
(B) Alcaraz hit back and broke him
(C) Alcaraz retired hurt
(D) Shelton won the set

5. How long had Alcaraz been out with a wrist injury before the US Open?

(A) One year
(B) Two weeks
(C) Four months
(D) Four weeks

6. How many ATP Masters 1000 titles has Alcaraz won in total?

(A) Nine
(B) Seven
(C) Five
(D) Twelve

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Carlos Alcaraz: He said the title was something he had been chasing for a long time, and that facing Ben Shelton was one of the toughest challenges in tennis right now.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):